

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN TIMOR-LESTE

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes what happens to the coast, land, and finite wealth of Timor-Leste — and here the fight has an unusual character, because the great destructive project is bound up with national pride and the nation's very survival, and the deepest question is not only whether a project harms a community but whether it is a wise use of a young nation's dwindling petroleum wealth. Timor-Leste is Asia's youngest country, a poor but genuine democracy born from a long and costly struggle for independence. Timor-Leste is Asia's youngest country, a poor but genuine and hard-won democracy born from a long and costly struggle for its independence, whose economy rests almost entirely on offshore oil and gas — and whose main producing field ceased output in 2024, leaving the sovereign Petroleum Fund to be drawn down while the government pursues a vast petroleum-infrastructure scheme along the south coast. That scheme, known as Tasi Mane, would build a supply base, a refinery, an LNG plant, a highway, and airports across the southern shore. It would build a supply base, an oil refinery, an LNG plant, a highway, and airports across the length of the southern shore, to bring the country's offshore gas onshore for processing rather than piping it, as before, to Australia. It promises jobs and industry and dignity; but it would take more than a thousand hectares of community farmland, fishing grounds, and salt farms. It promises jobs and industry and national dignity; but it would take well over a thousand hectares of community farmland, fishing grounds, and salt farms, has already displaced families in anticipation, and is judged by economists and the country's own respected analysts to be unlikely to recover its costs, and is judged by international economists and the country's own respected independent analysts to be unlikely ever to recover its costs — an expensive bet on petroleum by a nation that economists urge to diversify. This guide will be honest that opposing such a project touches national pride, that the country is poor and desperate for revenue, and that there is no landmark community victory to point to; but it will show that the levers here, in a real democracy with a capable civil society, are strong.

The Timorese story teaches two things about opposing destructive projects here, and this guide states both plainly. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the affected community, the evidence, the coalition, and the pressure on the deciders — pressed together. The second is distinctly Timorese, and it is what gives this guide its real force. **Because Timor-Leste is a functioning democracy with a free press, a fierce civil society forged in the independence struggle, real institutions, and a national debate over how to spend its finite petroleum wealth, the levers are open and domestic: the resource-governance argument over the Petroleum Fund, the capable watchdog organisations, the parliament and the audit institutions, the influential church, and the community's own land rights.** That combination — the resource-governance debate, the civil society, the democratic institutions, the church, and land rights — is the distinctive lever here, and this guide is built around it, because in a young democracy the fight over a dubious megaproject can be waged openly, in the institutions and the public square, as much as on the affected land itself.

But the same story carries honest qualifications this guide states plainly and takes seriously. **The project is wrapped in national pride and the promise of prosperity, the country is poor, and opposition can be cast as unpatriotic.** Bringing the nation's gas onshore is seen by many as a matter of sovereignty and dignity — the difference between being a country that merely collects royalties and one that runs its own industry — so to oppose the megaproject can be painted as opposing the nation's advancement, even as its people are displaced and its wealth spent on works that may never pay. This guide does not pretend the choice is simple, or that development is unwanted, or that the sovereignty aspiration is not deeply felt. What it shows is how, in a real democracy weighing its finite wealth, a community can use the resource-governance debate, the civil society, the institutions, the church, and its land rights to insist that development be wise, just, and protective of the land and the nation's future — holding the national interest and the community together rather than against each other.

Most communities do not know HOW to use the levers a young democracy offers. They see the surveyors, the displacement, the promised refinery, the highway cutting through their farms — and either accept it as the price of progress or protest in ways that pit them against national pride, and rarely engage the resource-governance debate, the watchdog organisations, the parliament and audit institutions, the church, or their own land rights. The gap between wise development and wasteful, harmful development is here often a gap of method — the method of using the resource-governance argument, the civil society, the institutions, the church, and land rights together, and of holding the nation's interest and the community's together.

This guide shows what actually works — inside the Timorese reality as it is, which is a real but poor democracy weighing its finite wealth. It is written for the person who sees the coast, the farmland, and the nation's savings staked on a doubtful petroleum megaproject — and who wants to know what can be done in a young democracy where the project is wrapped in pride and promise. The answer is a real yes: the levers are open and strong — the resource-governance debate, the civil society, the institutions, the church, and land rights — with the honest qualifiers that the project touches national pride, the country is poor and revenue-hungry, and there is no landmark victory to promise, only real, open democratic levers and the work of insisting that development be wise and just. A note on who this guide is for, and on the spirit in which it should be used. It is for the person willing to do the patient, open, and unifying work of a real democracy — documenting the harm, building the economic case, engaging the parliament and the courts, enlisting the civil society and the church, and always framing the effort as the nation's own prudent interest — rather than the confrontational protest that a repressive state might force upon a community. That is not a weaker form of action but, in Timor-Leste's conditions, the most effective one, because here the levers that genuinely deliver are the open institutions, the wealth debate, and the moral and civic voices of a real democracy, and these reward the patient, credible, unifying approach. Anyone tempted to frame the fight as community against nation should understand that doing so hands the government its easiest victory, and that the real, reachable path runs through claiming the national interest for wise stewardship. This guide is an honest map of that open, democratic, and unifying path — the path of a community standing as its nation's prudent conscience.

The Strategic Framework

Effective efforts follow the same underlying pattern, whether the goal is to protect land and coast from a petroleum cluster, or to insist the nation's wealth be spent wisely:

```
STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION  (find the project, the harm, and the wealth question)
      |
STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION          (build the evidence -- harm and cost)
      |
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION        (build the community and the coalition)
```

STEP 4: LEGAL, REGULATORY & RESOURCE-GOVERNANCE (courts, parliament, the Fund)
STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY (make it a national wealth-and-land debate)

These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. The evidence of harm and of doubtful cost feeds the resource-governance debate, the institutions, the civil society, and the public at once; the community organises; a watchdog's analysis, a parliamentary question, or a land-rights claim is both pressure and a spur to the next. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, gives itself the best — if still difficult — chance of insisting on development that is wise, just, and protective of the land and the nation's future.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Timor-Leste's — a real democracy, a capable civil society, a national wealth debate, and strong community land ties — give communities a distinctive set:

- **The resource-governance debate.** The **national argument over the Petroleum Fund and how to spend the nation's finite wealth** is a powerful, open lever against a doubtful megaproject.
- **The civil society.** The **capable, respected watchdog organisations** that monitor the petroleum sector are a distinctive domestic strength.
- **The democratic institutions.** The **parliament, the audit institutions, the courts, and the free press** are open and real, and have checked petroleum contracts before.
- **The church.** The **influential Catholic Church**, central to the nation's life, is a distinctive moral lever.
- **Community land rights.** The **community's strong ties to land and coast** are a real and legitimate foundation.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers prevail, or that opposing a proud national project is easy. There is **no landmark win**; the project is **wrapped in national pride**; the country is **poor and revenue-hungry**; and displacement has **already happened**. This guide takes those limits seriously — it states them plainly, and it holds the nation's interest and the community's together — and shows how to use the real, distinctive tools this democracy offers — the resource-governance debate, the civil society, the institutions, the church, and land rights — to insist on wise and just development, honestly acknowledging the pride, the poverty, and the absence of a landmark victory.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see. Before you spend a single week, map who actually decides the project's fate, at which level, and where the leverage is real. And map where the resource-governance debate, the civil society, the institutions, the church, and land rights apply, because in Timor-Leste a doubtful megaproject is best met not by pitting community against nation, but by using the open levers of a real democracy — the argument over the nation's finite wealth, the capable watchdogs, the parliament and audit institutions, the church, and the community's land rights.

The Levels of Decision

A Timorese project runs through several tracks, most of them open and reachable in a real democracy.

The government and the plan. The **government and its development plan** drive the megaproject — the clusters, the highway, the pipeline vision — and are answerable, in a democracy, to the parliament, the audit institutions, the courts, the press, and the voters.

The Petroleum Fund and the wealth question. The **Petroleum Fund and the national debate over the nation's finite wealth** is where a doubtful, costly megaproject is most vulnerable — because spending savings on works that may never pay is a question every citizen has a stake in.

The parliament and audit institutions. The **parliament, the audit chamber, and the courts** can scrutinise, question, and check petroleum contracts and spending — and have rejected a megaproject contract before.

The civil society and the church. The **capable watchdog organisations and the influential church** are distinctive Timorese forces that can analyse, expose, and lend moral weight.

The communities and their land. The **affected communities and their strong land rights** are the legitimate foundation, in a nation where land and coast are life and heritage.

The Journey of a Project

A Timorese megaproject — a supply base, a refinery, an LNG plant, a highway — moves from a plan and a budget line, through contracts and land-taking, toward the displacement and the harm, with the **community's evidence, the resource-governance debate, the institutions, the civil society, the church, and land rights** able to intervene. **The wealth debate and the democratic institutions are where a doubtful megaproject is most reachable, and land rights are the community's foundation** — and using them together is the distinctive Timorese approach. The distinctive levers are the **resource-governance debate, the civil society, the institutions, the church, and land rights**. Find out exactly where the project stands, and, crucially, **what land and coast would be lost, whether the spending is wise, and how the institutions, the civil society, the church, and land rights can be engaged**, because those are where a project can genuinely be met.

Follow the Project, the Land, and the Money

Behind a project stand the government, the plan, and the nation's finite wealth. Trace who decides, who profits, and — importantly here — **what land, coast, and livelihoods would be lost, whether the spending will ever pay, how it affects the Petroleum Fund and the nation's future, and how the institutions, the civil society, the church, and land rights can be engaged**. Two questions unlock most Timorese efforts: **What would be lost, and is the spending wise?** and **Which lever — the wealth debate, the institutions, the civil society, the church, land rights — can meet it?** The resource-governance debate, the civil society, and the institutions are, together, the heart of most such efforts here. Everything else in a Timorese effort ultimately serves these: the documentation exists to prove the harm and the doubtful cost; the community organising exists to unite it as the nation's prudent conscience; and the media exists to carry the wealth-and-land question into the national debate. Keep the resource-governance argument, the capable civil society, and the open institutions at the centre of every submission, filing, and campaign, and the effort retains a clear spine that joins the community's land to the nation's finite wealth, and that speaks for the whole country's interest rather than one community's alone.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that shape a project, because they are the community's levers. The **government and its plan**; the **Petroleum Fund and the wealth debate**; the **parliament, the audit**

chamber, and the courts; the watchdog organisations and the free press; the church; and the communities and their land rights. In Timor-Leste, the **resource-governance debate, the civil society, the institutions, the church, and land rights** are the most distinctive levers, and nearly all are open and domestic in a real democracy. Each is a separate front, and a project shown to harm land and coast, to spend the nation's wealth unwisely, and to violate the community's rights, can genuinely be scrutinised and reshaped — as the audit chamber once checked a megaproject contract — though, honestly, the project is wrapped in national pride, the country is poor, and displacement has already happened, and this guide will keep saying so, and keep holding nation and community together.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit effort, calibrate honestly — and here that means acknowledging that the project touches national pride, that the country is poor and revenue-hungry, and that some displacement has already happened, even as the open democratic levers give real leverage. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how resource-governance and megaproject conflicts tend to go in young democracies like Timor-Leste, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the community can **document the harm and the doubtful cost**, whether it can **engage the resource-governance debate, the institutions, and the civil society**, and whether it can **hold nation and community together**. Where the harm is provable and the spending is shown to be unwise, the open levers here are real; but temper every figure with the honest knowledge that the project is wrapped in pride, the country is poor, and revenue is desperately sought.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	15–25%	weeks	low	Basis for every other step
Harm-and-cost case	40–60%	weeks–months	low	The loss and the doubtful spending, shown
Resource-governance debate	40–60%	months	low	The wealth question raised nationally
Civil-society partnership	45–65%	months	low	Capable analysis and advocacy
Democratic institutions	40–60%	months–years	low–moderate	Scrutiny; a contract or budget checked
The church	35–55%	months	low	Moral weight added
Community land rights	40–60%	months–years	low–moderate	Land defended; consent required
All levers together	45–65%	months–years	moderate	Development made wiser and juster

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Timor-Leste's real strengths are the open democratic levers: the **resource-governance debate**, the **civil society**, the **institutions**, the **church**, and **land rights**. Its constraints are specific and honest: the project is **wrapped in national pride**, the country is **poor and revenue-hungry**, and displacement has **already happened** — so progress comes through the open, democratic, and moral levers, and through holding nation and community together.

Effectiveness Visualization

Pitting community vs nation:	■■■■	backfires
Reshaping / wiser spending:	■■■■■■■■■■	often achievable
Defending land / consent:	■■■■■■■■■■	often achievable
The record / the case made:	■■■■■■■■■■	more reliable than a stoop

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **The civil society and the resource-governance debate** — Timor-Leste's distinctive strengths; capable analysis and the national wealth argument.
2. **The democratic institutions** — the parliament, audit chamber, courts, and press, open and real.
3. **Community land rights** — the legitimate foundation, in a nation where land is life.
4. **The church** — the distinctive moral weight.
5. **The harm-and-cost case** — the provable loss and the doubtful spending.

What These Campaigns Actually Show

A few honest patterns recur. **The wealth debate is a real lever** — a doubtful, costly megaproject is vulnerable to the national argument over finite savings. **Civil society is capable** — Timor-Leste's watchdogs produce respected analysis that shapes debate. **The institutions can check** — the audit chamber has rejected a megaproject contract before. **Pride complicates opposition** — the project is wrapped in sovereignty and dignity. **Land rights are strong** — the community's ties to land and coast are deep and legitimate. The through-line: **document the harm and the doubtful cost; engage the resource-governance debate, the institutions, and the civil society; add the church's weight; defend the community's land rights; and hold nation and community together** — because a community that does can genuinely reshape the spending, defend the land, and demand consent, while being honest that the project is wrapped in pride, the country is poor, and there is no landmark victory yet.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective effort begins by finding the exact project and harm — and the wealth question and the leverage the community holds in a real democracy. Vague concern goes nowhere, and pitting community against nation backfires; an effort aimed at "the supply base taking this farmland and coast, whose cost the analysts doubt, which the wealth debate and the institutions can scrutinise and the community's land rights can defend" is a real, workable effort — the kind Timor-Leste's open levers can deliver. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

- 1. What would be lost?** This is the first question here. What **land, coast, farmland, fishing grounds, and livelihoods** would the project take — the hectares of community land, the salt farms, the fishermen's docks, the homes.
- 2. Is the spending wise?** Whether the project is a **wise use of the nation's finite petroleum wealth** — the distinctive resource-governance question, since a costly work that never pays harms the whole nation.
- 3. Which institutions and the wealth debate apply?** How the **parliament, the audit chamber, the courts, and the national Petroleum Fund debate** can scrutinise the project and its spending.
- 4. Which civil society and the church apply?** Which **watchdog organisations** can analyse and expose the project, and how the **church** can lend moral weight.
- 5. How are land rights and national pride held together?** How the **community's land rights** can be defended, and how opposition can be framed as **wise stewardship of the nation's wealth**, not as opposition to the nation.

A Worked Example

Suppose a petroleum supply base or refinery will take a community's farmland and coast, its cost doubted by the analysts, its promise wrapped in national pride.

Working the five questions: **what would be lost? Is the spending wise? Which institutions and the wealth debate apply? Which civil society and the church apply?** And how are land rights and national pride held together? The deciders are the government and its plan, with the wealth debate, the institutions, the civil society, the church, and land rights as the levers.

Within a season the effort has moved from "the nation has decided and to object is unpatriotic" to a real effort: document the harm and the doubtful cost; engage the wealth debate and the institutions; enlist the civil society and the church; and defend the community's land rights — all framed as insisting the nation spend its wealth wisely and treat its people justly, not as opposing the nation. That is a workable effort suited to Timor-Leste — one that holds nation and community together. Notice what the five questions accomplish, and how they suit a fight of this particular character: they lift the matter from a narrow local grievance into a national question that a whole democracy can engage. The harm becomes documentable loss of land and livelihood; the wisdom of the spending becomes a question every citizen has a stake in, because it concerns the nation's shared finite wealth; the institutions and the wealth debate become concrete, open arenas in which to press it; the civil society and church become powerful allies; and the framing question — how to hold land rights and national pride together — keeps the effort from the fatal error of appearing to oppose the nation. That translation — from a local displacement that a government could brush aside as an obstacle to progress into a national debate about the wise stewardship of a hard-won inheritance — is the first and most important thing a Timorese effort does, because it moves the fight onto ground where the whole democracy, and not just the affected community, has reason to engage.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on — and here, where the case must persuade the institutions, the civil society, the church, and a proud public, sound evidence of both the harm and the doubtful cost is decisive. A parliamentarian, an auditor, a watchdog analyst, and a journalist all move on evidence — and in Timor-Leste, a clear record of the land and coast lost, and of the spending's doubtful wisdom, is precisely what an effort turns into a real result, so build it well. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Project, the Cost, and the Deciders

Get the facts the case turns on. Identify the **project, its components, its budget, and the land and coast it would take**; and, crucially here, gather the evidence on its **cost and viability** — the analysts' and economists' judgements on whether it will ever recover its investment, and its effect on the Petroleum Fund. Establish the deciders and the doubtful economics precisely, because in Timor-Leste the distinctive case is not merely that a project harms a community, but that it may be an unwise use of the nation's finite and dwindling wealth.

Layer 2: The Loss — Land, Coast, and Livelihood

Document what would be lost. Establish the **physical and environmental harm** — the farmland, salt farms, fishing grounds, and coast taken; the displacement; the pollution and health and ocean risks of an industrial petroleum complex — drawing on **the watchdog research, the environmental studies, and community knowledge**, much of which exists for a project as scrutinised as this one. And establish the **human harm** — the families displaced, the livelihoods and heritage lost. Photographs, maps, and testimony make the loss undeniable, and the cost evidence makes it a national question.

Layer 3: The Loss, the Cost, the Rights, and the Wealth Question

Finally, document the case. Does the **environmental and human harm** show a real loss? Is the **spending unwise**, harming the nation's finite wealth? Whose **land rights** does it violate, and was there consent? And how does the case bear on the **Petroleum Fund and the nation's future**? Each is a separate element, and together they make a case that can be pressed in the institutions and the public square, and framed as wise

national stewardship. This is the layer that most often decides these efforts, because a documented loss, a doubtful cost, a violated right, and a clear stake in the nation's wealth are exactly what let a Timorese community argue for wise and just development. Build it well, and the wealth debate, the institutions, the civil society, and land rights become the community's genuine strength. One practical note on building this layer: the doubtful cost is the element that most distinguishes a Timorese case and most repays careful work, because it is what elevates a local harm into a national question the whole democracy must weigh. A displacement or a land-taking, on its own, is a local matter a determined government can push through as the price of progress; but the same displacement, shown to be part of a megaproject that respected analysts judge unlikely ever to recover its cost — a project draining the nation's finite savings for works that may stand unused, as an airport already does, overgrown with weeds — becomes a question of national prudence that every citizen has reason to ask. So the file should establish, as rigorously as the evidence allows and drawing on the country's own capable analysts, exactly what the project will cost, what it is likely to return, and what its pursuit means for the Petroleum Fund and the nation's future. It is this economic case, more than the local harm alone, that gives a small community a claim on the whole nation's attention, and it is worth building with the greatest care.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Evidence in hand beats evidence you assume exists. Here is where the material tends to live in a Timorese effort, and how to get it — with the **harm**, the **cost**, the **land rights**, and the **wealth question** at the center. Treat this as a checklist to work through, not a menu to admire.

The Project and Cost Record

Start with the project and its economics. **Project plans, budgets, contracts, and the Strategic Development Plan** establish what is intended and what it will cost; and, decisively here, gather the **analyses of the project's viability** — the economists' and watchdogs' judgements on whether it will recover its costs, and its effect on the Petroleum Fund. Much of this exists in the respected civil-society research and the economic studies on the megaproject, and is reachable in a country with a free press. Establish exactly **what the project is, what it costs, and whether it will ever pay**, because the doubtful economics are the distinctive lever.

The Land, Coast, and Livelihood Evidence

This is the heart of the local file. Gather the **physical and environmental evidence** — the hectares of community land taken, the farmland and salt farms and fishing grounds lost, the coast and ocean at risk, the pollution and health hazards of an industrial petroleum complex — drawing on **maps, environmental studies, and the watchdog research**. And gather the **human evidence** — the families displaced, the livelihoods and customary and cultural uses lost. Photographs, maps, and testimony make the loss vivid and credible, and ground the national argument in real lives.

The Wealth and Governance Record

Document the wealth question, because it is the distinctive Timorese lever. Gather the evidence on the **Petroleum Fund's decline**, the **end of the main producing field**, the **economists' calls to diversify**, and the **judgement that the megaproject may never pay** — so the case can show that the project risks the nation's finite savings and future. A community that can frame its local harm within the national question — is this a wise use of our dwindling wealth? — turns a local grievance into a national cause every citizen shares. This is worth dwelling on, because the Petroleum Fund occupies a place in Timorese national life

that gives this framing unusual force. The Fund is not an abstract accounting entity but the tangible fruit of the nation's one great resource, carefully saved and widely understood as the inheritance meant to carry the country beyond the age of oil — the security of future generations in a poor nation with few other assets. To spend that inheritance down on a megaproject the experts doubt is therefore not merely a budgetary choice but a decision about whether the nation squanders or safeguards the future it fought for. A community that frames its fight in these terms — not as blocking a project but as guarding the nation's future against an imprudent gamble with its finite savings — speaks to something Timorese citizens feel deeply, and enlists the widest possible concern for what might otherwise seem a distant, local matter.

The Rights and Consent Record

Document the land rights and consent. Gather the **community's land tenure and customary rights**, and whether **free, informed consent** was sought and given for the taking of land — since in a real democracy a project that violates rights or proceeds without genuine consent is vulnerable in the courts and the public square. And gather the record of any **displacement already done in anticipation** of the project. A community that can show its rights violated or its consent bypassed holds a strong, legitimate lever.

The Allies and the Community

Finally, map the human terrain. Who is affected — the coastal and farming communities, the fishers, the displaced, the future? Who are the allies — the **watchdog organisations, the sympathetic parliamentarians, the church, the free press, the international observers**? And how is the community organised, and its cause framed as **wise national stewardship**? A Timorese effort is advanced through the community and its allies in an open democracy, framed as insisting on wise and just development — so map that coalition and those levers deliberately.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Evidence does not move deciders by itself. A community — organised, informed, and framing its cause as wise national stewardship — is what turns evidence into action, in a real democracy. And here, distinctively, the community's task is not to oppose the nation's development but to insist that development be wise and just — so that the defence of the land and the good stewardship of the nation's wealth become one cause, and the community stands as the nation's prudent conscience rather than its opponent.

Why the Community Is Decisive — and Must Stand With the Nation

In Timor-Leste, an organised community is decisive, but it is strongest when it frames its cause as the nation's own wise interest, not against it. The community supplies what an effort runs on: the affected voices, the local and land knowledge, the legitimacy, and — distinctively — the moral standing to say that a nation forged in sacrifice should not squander its wealth or displace its people unwisely. When a community organises to defend its land and to insist the nation spend wisely, it becomes a genuine force in a real democracy. **A united community here is not against the nation; it is the nation's prudent conscience, defending the land and the finite wealth that belong to all — the strongest and most legitimate ground on which a Timorese effort can stand.** This reframing is the single most important strategic move in the guide, and it deserves to be understood fully, because in Timor-Leste it is the difference between an effort that is welcomed and one that is dismissed. A project cast by the government as the fulfilment of independence — the nation at last running its own industry rather than sending its gas abroad — has a powerful emotional claim on a people who sacrificed enormously for their sovereignty, and a community that appears to oppose that dream can be painted, however unfairly, as ungrateful or unpatriotic. But the

community that reframes its cause as protecting the very thing the nation fought for — its land, its people, and the finite wealth that is the whole nation's inheritance — turns that emotional claim to its own side. It says, in effect: we too love this nation and honour its sacrifice, and precisely because we do, we insist that its hard-won wealth not be squandered and its people not be displaced for a project the experts doubt. This is not a rhetorical trick but a truthful reframing, and it is the ground on which a Timorese community stands strongest.

Finding the Affected Community

Begin with those the project touches most — the **coastal and farming families, the fishers, the salt-farmers, and those displaced or to be displaced** — whose land and livelihoods are at stake. Widen to all who have a stake in the nation's finite wealth, which is every citizen. Name the shared stake — **our land, our coast, our livelihoods, and our nation's wealth and future** — because in a country where the land is life and the petroleum savings are the nation's inheritance, the defence of both unites the community and the country. There is a real and unusual power in this joining of the local and the national, because it means a Timorese community is never fighting only for itself. A community defending its own farmland against a supply base is easy for a government to portray as a narrow, local obstacle to national progress; but a community that frames its fight as also a defence of the nation's finite savings — the Petroleum Fund that belongs to every citizen and that a doubtful megaproject would help to drain — speaks for the whole country's interest, not merely its own. This alignment of the community's local stake with every citizen's stake in the national wealth is what allows a small coastal community to command national attention and support, because it is asking the whole nation a question the whole nation must answer: is this how we should spend the inheritance we bled for? Framed this way, the community's land and the nation's future are defended in the same breath.

Coalition-Building in a Democracy

A community allied is stronger than a community alone, and in Timor-Leste the coalition is broad and open. Reach to the **watchdog organisations** that analyse the petroleum sector; the **sympathetic parliamentarians and officials**; the **church**; the **free press**; the **academics and economists**; and the **international observers**. Frame the coalition around wise national stewardship and the defence of land and livelihood, uniting the local and the national. Build breadth openly, as a real democracy allows, and lend the community's cause the weight of the nation's respected voices.

Sustaining the Effort

Timorese efforts can be sustained through the open, ongoing democratic debate and the community's organisation. Keep the community **informed, organised, and framed as the nation's prudent conscience**; mark real steps — a watchdog analysis published, a parliamentary question raised, a contract scrutinised, land rights asserted, the church's voice added. And keep the effort grounded in wise stewardship and land rights, which unite rather than divide. The effort that lasts is the one that stays organised, uses the open democratic levers, and holds the nation and the community together as one cause. Sustaining such an effort is helped, in Timor-Leste, by the openness of the democracy itself, which gives a community renewable proof that its voice is being heard and its arguments are landing — a watchdog report that shapes the national conversation, a parliamentarian who takes up the question, a newspaper that runs the story, a church leader who speaks. These visible marks of an open democracy at work renew a community's energy in a way that would be impossible under a repressive state, where such responses would never come. The discipline is to keep using and celebrating these democratic openings — the reports, the questions, the coverage, the moral voices — as proof that the effort is alive and effective,

while continuing patiently to press the wealth debate and defend the land, so that the community sustains itself on the genuine, visible workings of the democracy it helped to build.

STEP 4: LEGAL, REGULATORY & RESOURCE-GOVERNANCE CHALLENGES — THE COURTS, THE PARLIAMENT, AND THE PETROLEUM FUND

This is where a Timorese effort is realistically advanced — not by pitting community against nation, but through the **courts, the parliament and audit institutions, and the national Petroleum Fund debate** that a real democracy answers to, grounded in community land rights. Here the legal, regulatory, and resource-governance levers come together, because in Timor-Leste a doubtful megaproject is checked in the open institutions and the national argument over finite wealth.

Setting Expectations Honestly

First, the honest truth. The levers are **real and open, but the project has powerful backing**. The courts and audit institutions are **genuine and have checked petroleum contracts**, but the government pushes hard; the resource-governance debate is **powerful but contends with national pride and revenue hunger**; and land rights are **real but pressed by a project cast as the national interest**. What these levers realistically achieve is **a contract scrutinised, spending questioned, land defended, consent required, and the project reshaped or its worst components halted** — real outcomes, if not always a full stop. Enter this front clear-eyed: the courts, the parliament, and the wealth debate are Timor-Leste's distinctive levers, strongest when the **harm is provable, the cost is doubtful, and the community's rights are engaged** — and, crucially, all are open and domestic in a real democracy.

The Courts and the Audit Institutions

The first front is the institutions of scrutiny. The **courts** can address violations of land rights, environmental law, and due process; and the **audit chamber**, which reviews the state's contracts and spending, has already **rejected a megaproject contract** — a real precedent. Use the courts to defend land rights and demand due process and consent, and support the audit institutions in scrutinising the project's contracts and costs. These institutions are open, real, and have bitten before; a project that violates rights or wastes money is genuinely vulnerable to them. The precedent of the rejected megaproject contract deserves particular emphasis, because it is the clearest proof a Timorese community has that these institutions genuinely bite. When a contract for one of the megaproject's central components was put forward, it was not waved through as a foregone conclusion but reviewed by the audit institution and rejected — a demonstration that even a project backed by the nation's most powerful figures and wrapped in the language of national destiny remains subject to genuine, independent scrutiny of its soundness. This matters enormously for a community's morale and strategy, because it shows that the institutions of the young democracy are not merely decorative but capable of checking even the most cherished projects when the evidence warrants; and it means that a community bringing a rigorous, well-documented case about waste or illegality to these institutions is not shouting into the void but engaging bodies that have already shown themselves willing to say no. It is a precedent worth invoking, and building upon.

The Parliament and the Petroleum Fund Debate

The second and most distinctive front is the parliament and the wealth debate. The **parliament** debates and approves the budget and the spending of the nation's petroleum wealth, and is answerable to the voters;

and the **national argument over the Petroleum Fund** — its decline, the end of the main field, the economists' warnings, the doubt over whether the megaproject will ever pay — is a powerful, open lever. Bring the case to **sympathetic parliamentarians** and into the **national wealth debate**: argue that spending the nation's finite savings on a doubtful megaproject that displaces its people is unwise stewardship of a hard-won inheritance. This resource-governance argument reaches every citizen and is the distinctive Timorese lever. It is worth being clear-eyed about both the power and the limits of this wealth-debate lever, honestly. Its power is real and unusual: because the Petroleum Fund belongs to every citizen and its depletion threatens the whole nation's future, an argument that a project imprudently drains it commands attention no purely local grievance could, and it aligns the community's cause with the deepest national interest. Its limits are equally real: the same project is defended as the very means of securing the nation's future through its own industry, so the wealth argument contends with a powerful counter-argument about sovereignty and long-term revenue; and the pull of any promised income is strong in a poor nation whose main field has ended. Understanding both means deploying the wealth argument at its strongest — where the evidence of doubtful returns is clearest and the analysts most respected — while acknowledging honestly the sovereignty aspiration it contends with, and answering it not with scorn but with the case that true sovereignty is served by spending the nation's wealth wisely, not by spending it fast.

Community Land Rights and the Church

The third front is land rights and moral weight. The **community's land tenure and customary rights**, and the requirement of **genuine consent**, are real and legitimate levers — press for the recognition and defence of land rights and for true consent before any taking. And the **influential church**, central to the nation's conscience, can lend distinctive moral weight to the call for just and wise development. Pursued together — the courts and audit institutions, the parliament and wealth debate, land rights, and the church — these fronts are how a Timorese community insists on development that is wise, just, and protective of the land and the nation's future, standing as the nation's prudent conscience rather than its opponent. It is worth understanding why these fronts reinforce one another so well in Timor-Leste's particular situation. The courts and audit institutions supply the rigorous, legal check on rights and contracts, but move slowly and narrowly. The parliament and the wealth debate supply the broad, public, political pressure that can shift the whole national conversation, reaching every citizen through their shared stake in the finite wealth. Land rights supply the community's own legitimate, defensible foundation. And the church supplies a moral authority that transcends politics and speaks to a deeply faithful nation's conscience. Each covers the others' limits: the institutions where legal rigour is needed, the wealth debate where public pressure moves things, land rights where the community's own standing matters, and the church where moral weight is decisive. A community that grasps this division of labour — litigating and auditing where precision counts, arguing the wealth question where breadth counts, asserting land rights where legitimacy counts, and enlisting the church where conscience counts — uses each front for what it does best, and so makes the fullest use of the many open levers a real democracy uniquely offers.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Evidence does not speak for itself; you must aim it at each decider in the language that moves them. The same file of harm, cost, and land rights becomes different arguments for a parliamentarian, an auditor, the church, and the public. Translate deliberately, and always holding nation and community together.

For the Parliament and the Wealth Debate

Parliamentarians respond to **the national interest, the finite wealth, and the voters**. Frame the project as a question of wise stewardship: here is a costly megaproject that the analysts doubt will ever pay, spending the nation's dwindling savings and displacing its people. Give them the cost evidence and the harm, and argue that a nation forged in sacrifice must spend its inheritance wisely. Make it concrete: *here is the cost, here is the doubt, here is the finite wealth at risk*. This is the argument that reaches the whole nation.

For the Courts and Audit Institutions

The courts and auditors respond to **the law, the contracts, and due process**. Frame the harm as a violation of land rights, environmental law, or consent, or the spending as a contract that fails proper scrutiny — recalling that a megaproject contract has been rejected before. Give them the clean legal or financial case, through counsel or submission. These institutions act on rigour; give them rigour.

For the Church

The church responds to **justice, the dignity of the poor, and the good of the nation**. Frame the harm as an injustice to displaced families and a squandering of the nation's inheritance, and ask the church to lend its moral voice to the call for just and wise development. Give the church the human story and the moral stakes. Its voice carries distinctive weight in Timorese life.

For the Public and the Nation

The public responds to **a clear story of land, livelihood, and the nation's wealth**. Translate the file into a story anyone can grasp: families displaced and coast taken for a doubtful megaproject that may squander the nation's savings — and a community insisting the nation spend its hard-won wealth wisely and justly. Frame it as patriotism rightly understood: caring for the land and the inheritance that belong to all. Keep it accurate; credibility is quickly tested. And frame the effort as pro-nation, never anti-nation.

The Golden Rule

Never fabricate, never exaggerate, and never let the effort be cast as anti-national. Your credibility is your greatest asset, and it is quickly tested. State the harm precisely, show the doubtful cost honestly, and frame opposition as wise national stewardship. Hold nation and community together, and lend the effort the moral weight of the nation's own interest. A community that is precise, credible, and patriotic in the truest sense — defending the land and the nation's wealth — is far harder to dismiss than one that overreaches or is painted as opposing the nation.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media and attention convert your evidence into pressure — and in Timor-Leste, a real democracy with a free press, the story can be told openly, aimed at a nation weighing its finite wealth. The story — families displaced and coast taken for a doubtful megaproject that may squander the nation's savings, and a community insisting on wise and just development — is one that moves a young, proud nation.

Why Media Matters

The government, the parliament, the institutions, and the public behave differently when the harm and the doubtful cost are visible. Media does three things here: it **informs and unites the community and the public**, it **raises the national question** of whether the nation's finite wealth is being spent wisely, and it **frames the effort** as wise stewardship rather than opposition to the nation. Because Timor-Leste has a free press and an engaged public, open media is a genuine, powerful lever here — a doubtful megaproject

exposed to national scrutiny is one the government must justify. And the story of land, livelihood, and the nation's inheritance is one that resonates deeply. It resonates deeply because it touches the two things a Timorese audience holds most dear: the land, to which rural communities have profound ancestral and customary ties, and the hard-won independence of which the Petroleum Fund is the tangible economic fruit. A story that shows both under threat at once — families being parted from ancestral land and the nation's inheritance being gambled on a doubtful scheme — speaks to a people who fought and suffered for the right to govern their own land and resources, and who understand better than most the cost of losing control of them. Told with accuracy and without exaggeration, and framed as a defence of what the nation fought for rather than an attack on the nation's leaders, such a story can move a Timorese public that has every reason to care about the wise and just stewardship of the land and the wealth they sacrificed so much to call their own.

Crafting Your Narrative

Lead with the land, the people, and the nation's wealth, and frame it as patriotism rightly understood. The strongest frame is concrete and unifying: *our families are being displaced and our coast taken for a megaproject the experts doubt will ever pay, spending the savings our nation bled for — and we are fighting to make our nation spend its wealth wisely and treat its people justly*. Put the human loss and the national wealth question first, and the call for wise stewardship close behind, because that framing engages the nation without pitting community against country. Keep it scrupulously accurate; overstatement is quickly caught. The Timorese story is powerful because it joins the community's land to the nation's inheritance.

Choosing Your Channels

Match the channel to the audience. **Local radio and community networks** for the affected communities; the **national media** for the public and the parliament; the **church networks** for moral weight; and the **international and regional media** for wider attention and the resource-governance debate. Because Timor-Leste is an open democracy, the national channels matter most, and the free press is a real and reachable lever — the national wealth-and-land debate is the story's distinctive power. Tell it openly, as a democracy allows.

A Few Cautions

Stay accurate, patriotic in the truest sense, and constructive — the goal is wise and just development, not a story that pits community against nation or exaggerates. Frame the effort always as caring for the land and the nation's wealth, and hold nation and community together. Handle the government and the politics factually, and mind that the project is bound up with national pride and sensitive politics. And sustain the story through the ongoing national debate over the nation's finite wealth. Above all, let the joining of the community's land to the nation's inheritance carry the story, because that is where a Timorese effort is strongest and most unifying.

EMAILS & LETTERS: TEMPLATES THAT WORK

Templates save time and prevent mistakes, but adapt every one — insert the real project, the real harm, and the real cost, keep it factual, and frame it as wise national stewardship. Here the wealth question, and unity, win.

8A: Requesting Information

Subject: Request for information — [project] at [location]

Dear [official / department],

I am writing on behalf of [community] regarding [project] affecting [location]. To understand and respond to this matter, we request the **project plans, budget, and contracts**, the **environmental and social assessments**, and information on the project's **cost, viability, and effect on the Petroleum Fund**. We wish to ensure our nation's wealth is spent wisely and our community treated justly.

We would be grateful for a response by [date].

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8B: Letter to a Parliamentarian

Subject: Is [project] a wise use of our nation's finite wealth?

Dear [parliamentarian],

We write regarding [project] at [location], which would take [community land and coast] and displace [families], and which economists and analysts doubt will ever recover its cost — spending our nation's dwindling petroleum savings as the main field ends. We respectfully ask you to scrutinise this project's cost and wisdom in the parliament, and to insist that our nation's hard-won inheritance be spent wisely and its people treated justly. We attach documentation.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8C: Submission to the Audit Institutions

Subject: Scrutiny of the contracts and costs of [project]

To the [audit chamber],

We submit for your scrutiny the contracts and costs of [project] at [location], which we believe may represent an unwise use of public and petroleum-fund resources, given the analysts' doubts about its viability. Recalling that a megaproject contract has been reviewed and rejected before, we respectfully request examination of this project's financial soundness and procurement. We attach documentation.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8D: Letter to a Watchdog Organisation

Subject: Partnership on [project] at [location]

Dear [organisation],

Our community faces [project] taking our land and coast at [location], a project whose cost and wisdom are in doubt. We seek your partnership — your analysis, your monitoring of the petroleum sector, and your voice — to examine the project's cost and harm and to press for wise and just development. May we work together?

With respect,

[Name, community, contact]

8E: Media Pitch

Subject: Land taken and savings spent for a doubtful megaproject at [location]

Dear [journalist],

At [location], families are being displaced and coast taken for [project], a petroleum megaproject that experts doubt will ever pay — spending our nation's finite savings as the main field ends. There is a powerful national story here about land, livelihood, and the wise use of our hard-won wealth, and a community's fight for just development. We can provide the evidence, the cost analysis, and community voices.

Sincerely,

[Name, community, contact]

8F: Letter to the Church

Subject: Justice for displaced families and wise use of our nation's wealth

Dear [church leader],

Our community at [location] faces displacement and the loss of land and livelihood for [project], a costly megaproject whose wisdom is in doubt as our nation's petroleum savings dwindle. We ask the church to lend its moral voice to the call for justice for the displaced and for the wise and just use of the inheritance our nation bled for. We can share the human story and welcome your guidance.

With respect,

[Name, community, contact]

8G: Asserting Land Rights and Consent

Subject: Our land rights and consent regarding [project]

Dear [land authority / government],

Our community holds land and customary rights at [location] that [project] would take. We write to assert those rights and to insist that no land be taken without our **free, informed consent** and fair treatment, as justice and the law require. We request recognition of our rights and genuine consultation before any taking, and we can provide documentation of our tenure and use.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8H: Rallying the Community

Subject: Our land, our livelihoods, our nation's wealth — let us defend them wisely

Dear neighbours,

[Project] would take our land and coast and spend our nation's dwindling savings on a work the experts doubt. But together — through the parliament, the courts, the watchdogs, the church, and our own land rights — we can insist that our nation spend its hard-won wealth wisely and treat us justly. This is not against our nation but for it. Please join us: come to [gathering], share what you know, and add your voice. Let us

defend our land and our nation's future together.

With respect,

[Name, community]

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Sometimes a project is moving fast — a contract about to sign, a land-taking imminent, a budget about to pass — and you cannot run the full effort. Triage to the levers that work fastest here, which means the civil society, the wealth debate, and the institutions.

The First 48 Hours

Establish the essentials: **what land is being taken, and whether the spending is wise**. Identify the immediate pressure point — a **contract, a budget vote, a land-taking** — because that is what you must affect first. Reach the **watchdog organisations and sympathetic parliamentarians** at once, because in Timor-Leste's open democracy a capable watchdog's analysis and a parliamentary voice are the fastest routes to real leverage — and frame the matter as **wise national stewardship** from the start.

The Fastest-Moving Levers

Some levers work faster than others. **A watchdog's rapid analysis** can reach the parliament and press quickly. **A parliamentary question** can force scrutiny of a contract or budget fast. **The free press** can raise the national wealth question at once. **A submission to the audit chamber** can flag a doubtful contract, which has been rejected before. These outpace the slower work of litigation and land-rights recognition — which must follow — because in an open democracy analysis and scrutiny move fast.

Emergency Coalition-Building

You cannot build a full coalition overnight, but here you can reach the watchdogs, parliamentarians, and press fast. Reach immediately to the **watchdog organisations, the sympathetic parliamentarians, the church, and the free press**. A community, backed by a capable watchdog's analysis and a parliamentary voice, raising the national wealth question at a moment of decision, is the most a rapid Timorese effort can do — and in an open democracy it can move fast. Speed favours the prepared: know the project, the cost, and your allies before the vote.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Here, honestly, the system is tilted not by repression — for Timor-Leste is a real democracy — but by national pride, by the poverty that makes revenue desperate, and by the political weight behind the megaproject. This is the country's central, honest tilt, and the whole game has been shaped by it. Name it plainly, because pretending the field is level, or that pride and poverty do not weigh against a community, would be false.

Recognising a Tilted Field

The signs are specific and honest, and different from a repressive state's. **The project is wrapped in pride** — bringing the gas onshore is cast as sovereignty and dignity, so opposition is painted as unpatriotic. **The country is poor and revenue-hungry** — the main field has ended and the savings dwindle, making any promise of revenue tempting. **The project has powerful backing** — it is tied to leading political figures and

a national development vision. **But the field is open** — the press is free, the institutions real, the civil society capable. This is a tilt of pride and poverty, not of repression, and an effort here works it by using the open levers and reframing opposition as wise national stewardship.

Strategies for a Tilted Field

When the field is tilted by pride and poverty, use the open levers and change the frame. Lean on the **resource-governance debate** that makes wise stewardship, not opposition, the theme; the **capable civil society** whose analysis carries authority; the **open institutions** — parliament, audit chamber, courts — that can scrutinise; the **church's** moral weight; and the **community's land rights**. Reframe the whole effort as **patriotism rightly understood** — caring for the land and the finite wealth that belong to all — so that pride works for the community, not against it. And build the record and the argument even where the project's backing is strong, because in an open democracy a well-made case accumulates public and institutional weight over time. A tilt of pride and poverty is worked by claiming the national interest for wise stewardship, not by conceding it to a doubtful project.

The Honest Possibility of Losing

You may lose — the project may proceed, the land may be taken, the savings spent — and this guide will not pretend otherwise; the pride is strong, the poverty real, and the political backing powerful. But here, in an open democracy, the work is rarely wholly wasted: the **harm was documented, the doubtful cost exposed, the parliament and audit institutions engaged, land rights asserted, and the national debate shifted** — and every argument for wise stewardship makes the next project more accountable. Fight to make this project wise and just; if it proceeds, the scrutiny you brought, the rights you asserted, and the wealth debate you advanced will discipline the next, because in a young democracy the habit of demanding wise stewardship of the nation's wealth is itself a lasting victory. This is a consolation worth holding onto, because it is genuine and it endures. A young democracy is, in a real sense, still deciding what kind of country it will be — whether its institutions will be strong or hollow, whether its wealth will be guarded or squandered, whether its people's rights will be respected or brushed aside for the projects of the powerful. Every effort that insists, through the open and legitimate channels, that the nation's wealth be spent wisely and its people treated justly helps to set that pattern for the decades to come, whether or not it prevails on the particular project at hand. A community that fights this fight well, even in defeat, strengthens the habits of scrutiny, accountability, and respect for rights that a young democracy needs to endure — and in a country only a generation old, helping to build those habits is a contribution to the nation's future that far outlasts any single megaproject.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

In Timor-Leste, the petroleum sector and its megaprojects carry real risks of waste, patronage, and corruption — vast contracts, powerful figures, and a huge national fund create genuine temptations, and a major megaproject contract has already been rejected on scrutiny. This must be approached with care, but here, in an open democracy, the channels to address it are real and domestic.

Telling Capture from the Ordinary Tilt

Pride and poverty are the ordinary tilt; where contracts, land, and the nation's petroleum wealth flow to the connected rather than the public good, that is capture. The marks of capture are sharper: **contracts awarded without proper scrutiny, costs inflated beyond any return, land taken to benefit the connected, and the Petroleum Fund spent to reward patronage**. Timor-Leste's real strength is that these

can be pursued openly: **distinguish ordinary political enthusiasm from provable corruption**, and do not level accusations the evidence does not support — but where the evidence exists, the audit chamber, the courts, the parliament, the free press, and the capable civil society are genuine, domestic tools, and a megaproject contract has already been rejected on exactly such scrutiny.

Responding to Capture — Openly

Where capture is real, the response runs through the open democratic institutions. Use the **audit chamber** that reviews contracts and has rejected one before; the **courts** for unlawful dealings; the **parliament** for oversight of spending; the **free press** for exposure; and the **capable civil society** for rigorous analysis. Document meticulously, as the watchdogs do, and bring the evidence into the open institutions and the public debate, which in a real democracy can act on it. Timor-Leste's openness is its advantage: corruption here can be pursued through genuine domestic channels, not only from outside.

A Note on Safety and Care

This note governs everything here, though the danger is different from a repressive state's. Timor-Leste is a real democracy, not a police state, so open advocacy is possible and relatively safe — but the project is bound up with national pride and powerful figures, so the true risk is less physical than political: being cast as unpatriotic, or dividing the community against the nation. So frame the effort always as **wise national stewardship**, hold nation and community together, and pursue the open, institutional, and moral channels. Treat opponents and officials with respect and factual accuracy, and mind the sensitive national politics. Care here means protecting the effort's legitimacy by keeping it patriotic in the truest sense and scrupulously accurate — because an effort that is seen to defend the land and the nation's wealth, rather than to oppose the nation, is both safer and far more likely to prevail.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps in this guide are written in sequence but run in parallel, each feeding the others. Here is how they fit into a single, unifying effort in Timor-Leste.

The Parallel Effort

From the start, the five run together. **Documentation** builds the harm-and-cost-and-rights file. **Target identification** aims it at the levers. **Local opposition** organises the community as the nation's prudent conscience. **Legal, regulatory, and resource-governance** work presses the courts, the parliament, and the wealth debate. **Media** makes it a national land-and-wealth debate. The harm, the cost, and the rights feed all five at once — a documented harm is a case for the parliament, a matter for the audit chamber, a violation for the courts, and a national story together. Run in parallel, they compound; run one at a time, they stall — and here, spanning the community's land and the nation's wealth, they compound into a national cause.

A Rough Timeline

Early (weeks 1–8): establish the harm, the doubtful cost, and the land rights; identify the parliamentarians, the audit avenues, the watchdogs, and the community's tenure; begin documentation with the civil society's help. **Middle (months 2–18):** engage the parliament and the audit chamber; raise the wealth debate in the press; enlist the church; and assert land rights and consent through the courts and consultation. **Later (months and years):** press the national debate toward wise stewardship, defend the land, secure consent,

and reshape or check the project, and keep demanding accountable use of the nation's wealth whatever the outcome. A Timorese effort is open and public, and its work — shifting a national debate — is patient; pace it accordingly, and hold nation and community together throughout.

The Core Discipline

Through it all, hold the discipline that gives these efforts their force: **document the harm and the doubtful cost; engage the wealth debate, the parliament, the courts, and the audit institutions; enlist the civil society and the church; defend the community's land rights; and frame it all as wise national stewardship.** The community that presses all five, spanning its own land and the nation's wealth, and standing as the nation's prudent conscience, is the one that can genuinely make development wiser and juster — the kind of victory a young, poor, but real democracy allows.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Opposing a proud national megaproject in Timor-Leste is genuinely difficult, and bound up with national pride, poverty, and powerful backing, and this guide has been honest about that from its first line: there is no landmark victory, the project is wrapped in sovereignty and dignity, and displacement has already begun. And yet the effort is far from futile, because Timor-Leste is a real democracy with a free press, a capable civil society, open institutions, an influential church, and a national debate over its finite wealth — and those open, domestic levers are strong.

Some honest truths hold across every effort here. **The civil society and the resource-governance debate are the distinctive strengths, turning a local harm into a national question of wise stewardship. The open institutions — parliament, audit chamber, courts — are real and have checked petroleum contracts before. The community's land rights and the church's moral weight are legitimate and strong. But the project is wrapped in pride, the country is poor, and opposition must never be cast as anti-national.** Hold both truths at once: real, open, domestic democratic levers, and the honest weight of pride, poverty, and powerful backing.

Above all, keep the discipline — and the unity — that give these efforts their force. Document the harm and the doubtful cost. Engage the wealth debate, the parliament, the courts, and the audit institutions. Enlist the civil society and the church. Defend the community's land rights. And frame it all as wise national stewardship — because in a nation forged in sacrifice, an effort that defends the land and the finite wealth belonging to all, standing as the nation's prudent conscience, is the one that is both effective and just.

Timor-Leste is a young nation, poor but free, that bled for its independence and now stakes its future on its offshore gas — and along its southern coast a vast petroleum megaproject would take the farmland, the fishing grounds, and the salt farms of its people, and spend the nation's dwindling savings on works the experts doubt will ever pay, even as the main field runs dry; this guide has hidden none of it, nor pretended that the dream of running one's own industry is not deeply and understandably felt, and there is no landmark community victory here to promise you. But Timor-Leste is a real democracy, and that changes everything: the press is free, the civil society capable and respected, the parliament and courts and audit chamber open and real, the church a voice of conscience, and the debate over the nation's finite wealth one in which every citizen has a stake. There is no easy victory, and no landmark precedent to inherit; this guide has said so throughout, and insisted that the effort stand with the nation, not against it. But your land, your coast, your livelihoods, and your nation's hard-won wealth are worth defending, the open levers of your democracy are real and strong, and the patient work of documenting the harm, exposing the doubtful cost, engaging the parliament and the courts, and standing as your nation's prudent conscience is one your community can

genuinely do — and win development that is wise, just, and worthy of a nation that bled to be free. So can you.